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Rose-breasted Grosbeak

Pheucticus ludovicianus

QUICK STATS

Length	7.1 – 8.3 in (18 – 21 cm)
Wingspan	11.4 – 13.0 in (29 – 33 cm)
Weight	1.4 – 1.7 oz (39 – 49 g)
Lifespan	Up to 24 years (avg. 7 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Rose-breasted Grosbeak is one of the most spectacular songbirds to visit eastern North American feeders — the male's jet-black head and back, snow-white underparts, and vivid rose-red breast triangle make it unmistakable and unforgettable. Its large, pale, conical bill is built for cracking large seeds and fruit pits with ease. It arrives at feeders each spring as a migrant and breeding visitor, generating excited reports from birders across the eastern half of the continent. The female, streaked brown like a large sparrow, is far more cryptic but equally striking up close — and she sings almost as well as her mate.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Rose-breasted Grosbeak breeds in deciduous and mixed forests across central and eastern Canada and the northeastern United States, south through the Appalachians and east-central states. It winters in Central America and northern South America. It is a neotropical migrant, appearing at feeders across eastern North America in May and September during migration, when it regularly visits sunflower feeders during stopovers. It favors mature forest edges, woodland clearings, and suburban areas with large trees.

DIET & FEEDING

- Black-oil sunflower seeds — the most reliable feeder attractant
- Wild berries: serviceberry, cherry, elderberry, blackberry
- Seeds of trees: maple, ash, and box elder samara
- Insects and larvae during the breeding season
- Flower buds and young leaves in spring
- Safflower seed — readily taken, less attractive to House Sparrows

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Rose-breasted Grosbeaks are surprisingly docile at feeders for such a large, boldly marked bird — they often feed quietly alongside other species, unlike the aggressive Blue Jay or Steller's Jay. Males arrive on the breeding grounds before females and establish territories through song rather than aggressive chasing. They are unusual among songbirds in that the male incubates eggs and broods nestlings almost as much as the female — and he sings quietly while sitting on the nest. Outside the breeding season they are loosely gregarious, traveling in small groups during migration.

NESTING & BREEDING

Rose-breasted Grosbeaks build a loose, flimsy cup nest of twigs, grasses, and plant material, typically 5–20 feet high in a deciduous tree or shrub. Both sexes build the nest and incubate the 3–5 pale blue-green eggs with brown spots for 13–14 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 9–12 days. The male is a devoted parent, singing softly while incubating. Pairs raise one brood per season. The male's rose breast patch is used in a threat display against rival males.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Rose-breasted Grosbeak's song is a rich, flowing carol often compared to an American Robin that has taken singing lessons — cleaner, faster, and with a more liquid quality. Both sexes sing, and the female sings a somewhat softer version while incubating. The call is a distinctive sharp, metallic "eek" or "squeak" — often described as sounding like a sneaker on a gym floor — that instantly identifies the species even when it cannot be seen.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
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The Rose-breasted Grosbeak population is estimated at 4.1 million individuals and has declined by approximately 52% since 1970 — one of the steeper declines among eastern forest songbirds. Loss of mature deciduous forest on both breeding and wintering grounds, window collisions during migration, and free-roaming cats are the primary threats. Sunflower feeders during spring migration provide a critical energy source for this long-distance migrant.

FEEDER TIPS

- Black-oil sunflower seeds on a hopper or platform feeder are the top attractant
- Grosbeaks appear briefly in May and September — watch for them during migration
- They often arrive with mixed flocks of warblers and tanagers in spring
- Safflower seed is a good alternative — most squirrels ignore it
- The call note — a sharp metallic squeak — is the best way to locate them in the canopy

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head & back (male)	Jet black
Breast triangle (male)	Rose-red — vivid, distinctive
Wing patches (male)	Bold white
Underparts (male)	White below the breast
Female — overall	Brown-streaked, like large sparrow
Bill	Large, pale conical — seed-cracking

COLOR ME!

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